conservative investor, which is actually how I felt after having just visited Mr. Klein. Mickey applauded my conservatism and said something like, "There's no reason to throw away what you've worked so hard to earn."

After he sat me in the guest chair next to his desk, I expressed a sudden interest in options, just to see how Mickey would respond. Soon he was telling me about his new red Porsche and his decision to take more chances and live for today. Then he told me about a client of his who'd made a fortune in options, most recently in the Warner-Lambert July calls. He punched in the symbols for Warner-Lambert and the up-to-date call-option prices appeared on the screen above our heads. "Options can be amazingly profitable if you know what you are doing," he said. "You have to be disciplined and not greedy. Plus you have to follow good research. At Merrill Lynch, we've got the best."

Though Mickey drew the line at commodities—"only fools would play commodities"—he sensed I'd do very well in options and that I had just the right personality for the job. I returned the compliment by guessing he'd do very well investing in options himself. "Me?" he laughed. "A broker? In this office, all the brokers have been killed playing options. Brokers don't make money on options. Brokers don't make money on any investments. Here, we even lose money on stocks."

Thanks to Mr. Todd's candor, I can pass along Useful Tip Number Nine:

Never invest in anything owned by your broker

After several days of walking in and out of offices and being no closer to finding the perfect broker than I'd been at the start, I pretty much decided to return to Richard Bermont, the Drexel Burnham man who'd been working with my wife. Certainly, I'd never even considered Linda Garrett of Prudential-Bache. The only reason I visited Ms. Garrett at her office was to ask her how she liked her new job. She'd been a secretary to an earlier broker of ours and had answered many of my frantic phone calls. Recently,